

Q Pegasystems has been organising the Pega Developers' Conference for two years now, to engage with the developers working on the company's technologies. What is your strategy to reach out to the developers, apart from organising events like these?

Well, we do a lot. We participate in the Java One conference, either as speakers, showcase our products, or have an information booth. Essentially, we would like to evaluate and participate in any kind of technology forum to engage with the developers' community in India.

Q With trends like SMAC (social, mobile, analytics and cloud) coming in, how has the life of a developer changed?

The array of technology that they need to understand has become bigger. The mobile, in particular, has caused a lot of confusion. The iOS platform is pretty mature and well organised. The Android platform, on the other hand, has a lot of variations, with different versions and it is very difficult to produce something that will work with every target device that somebody may show up with. BlackBerry has some adoption, but one of the big problems is to produce something for a target audience even when we have no control over the kinds of devices and software that they are going to use. In general, there are a number of technologies involved in building any serious application and it's very hard for one person to have expertise across the array. It's hard to co-ordinate and make everything work together in the way that's needed. It's a big challenge for people, so one of the things that we try to do is pull a lot of these technologies onto our platform. That way, if you learn the platform, you can at least get the basic application working and then you can enhance it in particular areas using special skills, if you want to.

Q A recent survey conducted by EMC suggests that there is a dearth of talent in India when it comes to the latest technologies for the mobile and the cloud. Do you agree?

There is a dearth of talent on the planet when it comes to those technologies! So why would India be any different? It's very hard to find people with a lot of experience. You can't find people with a lot of experience in a technology that is very new. I think India has an advantage as most of it is just mathematics. You produce so many engineers; you have so much talent here. It's a very aggressive and energetic community. Whenever I come to India, and I do so at least four times a year, I notice a huge surge in energy levels here.

The average age of our employees in India is way younger than the average age of our employees across the globe. That just gives India a tremendous advantage with which it is going to catch up. The Indian developers' community is going to be able to grow with the number of people who have the skills and experience faster than other people will grow because India has the numbers on its side.

"The open source community has matured a lot in the last few years and some of the technologies have been used by companies like Google, which has been great in injecting some discipline into the open source arena, to the extent that open source is now leading the way in providing a really good disciplined practice for developing software."

Pega has always regarded India not as a back office but as an R&D centre, and we believe in leveraging the people that we have here, to innovate. Our vice president emphasises how important the UI is, and most of our UI developers are in India. We have one team in Cambridge and the rest of our four to five teams for the UI are in India. Many of those teams have been with us since we opened office in India. Our No 1 employee is a UI engineer and she joined us on Day One. The experience and skills that we have here is a very fundamental part of engineering. So I think India is very well placed in terms of talent.

Q How have all these technologies affected or modified the development process in your company?

We have had to learn these technologies ourselves. We made a strategic move last year when we realised how important the mobile was. We looked around for a company that was well placed in the mobile space, which we could acquire to give us the kind of jumpstart in mobile technology. So we acquired Antenna Software – a leader in mobile technology. It has a huge operation in Bengaluru, and that's now a part of the Pega R&D centre in the city. We have had about a 100 people join us from Antenna and that gave us a big leg up. The acquisition comes with a whole new talent tool kit in terms of designing, debugging and integrating.

Our approach has always been to bring technology into the model. Our model is to encourage people to build on our platform. So we have had to adapt the model to embrace mobile concepts. It is very easy to project the application on to a mobile device and is no different than projecting it on a big screen. You just have to use a responsive UI but if you want some of the native capabilities, then you have to combine it into a hybrid model. We have been able to do that and integrate it with our model. So we have a lot of our engineers exposed to mobile device native programming, which is a whole new realm.

The other big change that we have started to see is in the open source community. The open source community has matured a lot in the last few years and some of the technologies have been used by companies like Google,